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Transition management

Learning objective:

8. Understand transition management as integration of the outputs of a project into business-as-usual.

8a) Know the basic requirements needed to support a successful transition, including considering business-as-usual throughout a project and planning for transition from the outset of the project.

Actions for a smooth transition

- Managing **stakeholder** expectations from the outset to increase the likelihood of the project outputs being accepted.
- Identifying and engaging with end users and project sponsors as **key stakeholders** throughout the project.
- Aligning needs with outputs where project constraints allow and **communicating** any digression from these.
- Setting the path for handover and acceptance by familiarising key **stakeholders** with the deliverables from the outset.
- **Clear communication** to reduce the risk of the project manager misunderstanding the requirements or the end users of the deliverables.

Preparing for new business-as-usual

- Preparing for the new business-as-usual should be considered early in the project life cycle.
- Business readiness should be considered as a continuous activity throughout the project to ensure that the intended users of the project outputs and those who will be expected to do things differently have bought into the outcomes.
- Business readiness activities can be carried out by the project team. These will require them to proactively engage with people to understand the processes and routines performed in business-as-usual, listen to and appreciate the sources of any resistance, and to identify, empower and motivate champions for the 'new normal'.
- Techniques, such as **change impact analysis**, will help understanding of:
  - physical or process impacts on the wider system
  - feelings about the change
  - knowledge or skills gaps that need to be addressed

Change impact analysis

Change impact analysis is a method of analysing the scope and scale of the change to the new business-as-usual state.

It helps to build an understanding of the organisational impacts on people, performance, processes, systems and culture.

It supports the planning and communication of change effectively, identifying potential issues and highlighting the resources required.

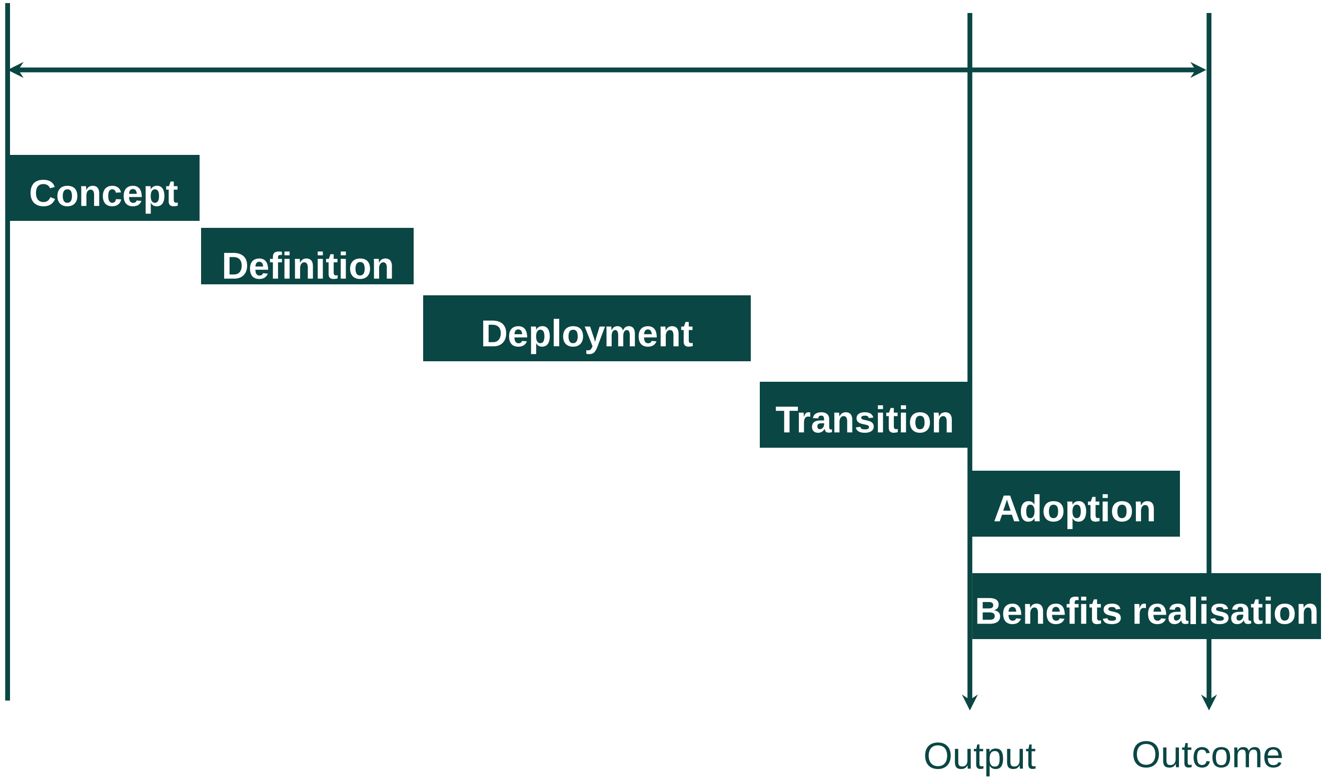
The change impact analysis process

1. Define the change, its purpose, objectives, scope and timeline.
2. Identify organisational areas such as people, performance, processes, systems, culture and individual stakeholders that will be impacted.
3. Evaluate the level of impact that the change will have on each area.
4. Develop an action plan to address the impacts of the change, which should be aligned with a common and shared vision, and communicated regularly throughout the project.

8b) Understand the importance of knowledge transfer in the transition process; this includes learning from experience and continuous improvement.

Progressive implementation

- The relationship between the people responsible for deployment of new capabilities and those responsible for business readiness and adoption in business-as-usual is carefully managed as part of governance.
- The sponsor is a key champion of this work to align the knowledge and experience of the temporary project team with the functional and operational teams to ensure the transfer of knowledge can take place.
- An **extended life cycle approach** would make the project team accountable for change management and therefore prevents the formation of knowledge boundaries between project teams and operational teams.
- It is important to provide effective learning and development from experience so that knowledge can be transferred to nurture future talent and users of the project outputs and to promote continuous improvement.



Transition planning

Transition planning starts at the beginning of a project. Information provided by the investing organisation is used to shape the solutions and plans, including details of what needs to be handed back to the organisation at the point of transition.

The transition process may include:

- Acceptance of all pertinent documentation (containing all prescribed information related to the deliverables, including guarantees and warrantees.)
- Acceptance certificates signed by the sponsor.
- Transfer of responsibility for the deliverables from the project team to the sponsor or users.
- Formal transfer of ownership.

Information handed over to business as usual

The information provided at handover for linear projects, or at relevant points of a project delivered under an iterative life cycle, can include:

- process maps
- project documentation
- ownership of supplier relationships
- ongoing licensing arrangements

As an example, for a building project, the handover information might include:

- user manuals
- operating procedures and maintenance manuals
- asset registers
- design information in the form of architectural and / or engineering drawings
- survey information
- health and safety files
- warranty information and commissioning certificates

Training on new systems, software and knowledge transfer should be organised by the project manager with the users at transition or at an appropriate point in the life cycle. For example, in an iterative or hybrid project, training and knowledge transfer may be required frequently, and before the end of a project.

8c) Understand how to engage stakeholders to agree a transition plan, including transfer of risks.

Engaging stakeholders with a transition plan

Early engagement

It is important to engage the relevant stakeholders early in the project. Stakeholder mapping will help to identify those that will be impacted by or interested in the transition process, such as senior leaders who will drive the transition, or departmental change agents providing personalised transition leadership to colleagues with existing or new roles.

Strategic alignment of goals and understanding of the future state

Collaborative planning with stakeholders throughout the project will help to develop a shared vision and a common understanding of the organisational and strategic impact, benefits and financial value goals expected.

Communicating benefits

Communicating benefits to stakeholders from an early stage in the project will support common understanding. Designating a benefits champion can support the communication of expected benefits with stakeholders throughout the project and help to prepare them for the transition process.

Agreeing a transition plan with stakeholders

A benefits management plan

This will define how the benefits will be managed through transition into operational use and the roles and responsibilities involved; benefits should be documented in terms of priority interdependencies, value, timescales, and ownership. Techniques such as MoSCoW (M – Must have; S – Should have; C – Could have; W – Won't have) can be used.

Mitigating conflict

The possibility of conflict between the user and the project manager should be considered; this may occur if the project does not meet its acceptance criteria, or user expectations.

Transfer of risk

Any remaining risks at project closure should be communicated to those involved in the adoption phase.